

COALITION BUILDING: HETEROGENEITY IN POLICY RESPONSIVENESS

HAS THE DEMOCRATIC PARTY IN THE US LET DOWN ITS CORE SUPPORTERS?

Many groups that have **historically consistently supported** the Democrats (e.g. blue collar workers) have been dissatisfied with the party's policies



Discuss why the Democratic party may have neglected its traditional support base in recent years

TODAY'S TOPIC

We learned so far: Threat of being fired disciplines leaders to not abuse powers, but not when

- ▶ **Winning coalition** is small
- ▶ Selectorate is **uninformed** about leaders' actions
- ▶ Selectorate is **attached** to leaders' characteristics

Today: Selectorate is diverse in their preferences, information and attachment

Who should leaders include in the **winning coalition**?

OUTLINE

COALITION BUILDING

APPENDIX: A GAME THEORY MODEL ON POLICY
RESPONSIVENESS AND POLICY OUTCOMES

SHORT NOTE ON LEADERS' CHARACTERISTICS

Selectorate may care about leaders' many characteristics

Some are visible before one becomes a leader, e.g.,

- ▶ Education, experience, charisma
- ▶ Ethnicity and race
- ▶ Previously revealed values
- ▶ General ability—if one already held leadership position

Some are visible only after, e.g.,

- ▶ Ability specific to the position
- ▶ General ability—if one has not yet held leadership position

Some are preferred by entire Selectorate while others are by only some (e.g., those in purple)

Today we focus on the latter

EXERCISE: SET UP

From groups of 5

Those not in any group should join any group as observers

Assign names: Blue, Red, B, R, I

Write your assigned name on a piece of paper visible to others

EXERCISE: SET UP

Blue is a leader

Red is a challenger

B, R, I are the selectorate

Winning coalition: any subset of the selectorate with **2** students

EXERCISE: HOMOGENOUS SELECTORATE

Each leader has **\$3**. They can

- ▶ Provide public good that delivers utility of **2** to every member of selectorate at price $p = \text{\$3}$
- ▶ Distribute **\$3** among the selectorate however she likes

Both leader propose a policy, and selectorate vote

Whoever wins, her policy is implemented

Play this game. What offer do both leaders make?

HOMOGENOUS SELECTORATE: LEADER'S OPTIMAL POLICY

Public goods delivers utility **2** to every selectorate member

There is not enough money to give utility of at least **2** to at least **2** people

If one leader provides public goods and the other does not, the latter loses

Recall Selectorate model: if the winning coalition is sufficiently large, the leader delivers public goods

EXERCISE: HETEROGENOUS SELECTORATE

The game is as before, but with the following addition

In addition to the payoffs from the adopted proposal, selectorate members receive:

- ▶ B receives 4 if Blue is selected and -4 if Red is selected
- ▶ R receives 4 if Red is selected and -4 if Blue is selected
- ▶ I does not receive any extra payoff

Play this game

What offer does do leaders make?

Who is in the leaders' winning coalition?

HETEROGENOUS SELECTORATE: LEADER'S OPTIMAL BEST RESPONSE

R votes for **Red** independent of the offer

B votes for **Blue** independent of the offer

Blue needs to convince **I** to vote for her

- ▶ If she promises public good, **I** is indifferent between leaders
- ▶ If she promises \$3 to **I**, she wins

Blue offers the entire budget to **I**

B and **I** are in her winning coalition

R receives nothing

IMPLICATIONS

Selectorate members who like a particular leader because of her characteristics, are **less responsive** to other policies offered by the same politician

Rational leader does not need to fight for this group's support

She chooses policies that **responsive** groups want

- ▶ In this game, **Blue** leader distributes money
- ▶ The same logic holds if **Blue** chooses policies that are preferred by only some members of the electorate

WHO SHOULD LEADER INCLUDE IN HER COALITION?

Those who already support her

- ▶ But they do not need any policy concessions

Those who are cheapest to buy

- ▶ Cater to independents, responsive voters

ROLE OF BEING INFORMED

Selectorate members can be responsive to leaders' policies only if they are informed about leaders' policies

Informed selectorate members are more likely to be included in the winning coalition and receive desired policies

INTEREST GROUPS INFORM AND INCREASE GROUP RESPONSIVENESS



Recall discussion about interest groups from API

Interest groups aim to create a group of **concentrated interests**

Interest groups also make groups more **responsive**

- ▶ E.g., NRA scores legislators on their support for gun rights and distributes those scores to members

HAS THE DEMOCRATIC PARTY IN THE US LET DOWN ITS CORE SUPPORTERS?

Blue collar workers historically formed partisan attachment to Democrats

Democrats were able to take their support for granted



Democrats focused on climate change and identity politics instead of redistribution, industry protectionism or immigration

CAN BLACK VOTERS MAKE BOTH PARTIES APPEAL TO THEM MORE?

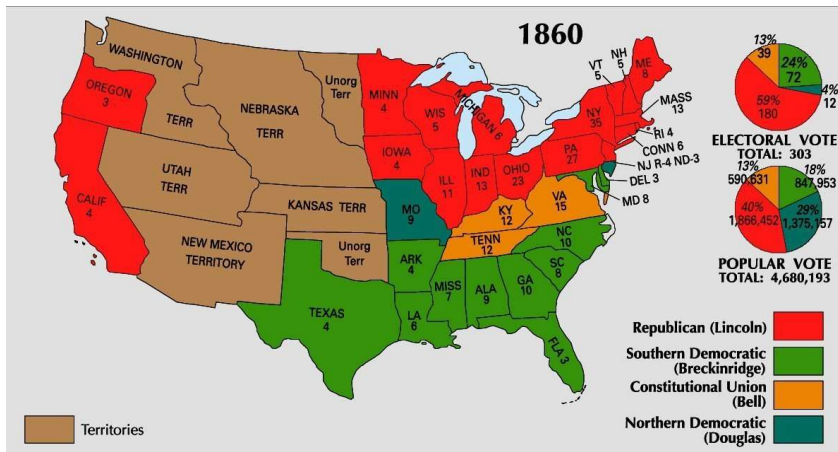
Black voters in the U.S. overwhelmingly vote for the Democratic party

There was a slight shift in the 2024 US Presidential election:

- ▶ Black voter turnout decreased by almost 6% vs 2020, higher than the 2% national average
- ▶ 15% of Black voters voted for Trump vs 8% in 2020

Could this shift be beneficial for Black voters?

THE 1860 ELECTION



THE 1860 ELECTION

In three of these “must win” states—Indiana, Pennsylvania, and Ohio—Douglas had considerable strength, especially in their southern counties, populated largely by settlers from the South. Although slavery was an issue everywhere, it was not always the dominant concern. Pennsylvanians were more interested in tariff protection, while voters in Indiana, Ohio, and elsewhere in the Northwest wanted free land for settlers and internal improvements to expand commerce there. [...] The antislavery vote would undoubtedly go Republican, but that alone could not build a majority among such diverse constituencies.

(Doris Kearns Goodwin – Team of Rivals: The Political Genius of Abraham Lincoln)

THE PROBABILITY OF BEING FLORIDA

U.S. presidential candidates travel to various states during campaigns

What states should they visit?

Winning states with many electoral votes is most beneficial

But that is not where the candidates travel the most...

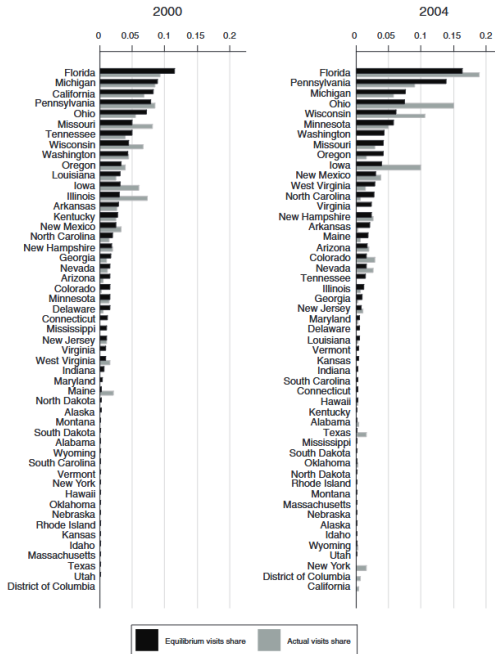


FIGURE 1. ACTUAL AND EQUILIBRIUM SHARES OF CAMPAIGN VISITS

KEY LESSONS

The leader should (will) include in her coalition:

- ▶ Those who already support her
 - ▶ But they do not get policy concessions
- ▶ Those who are cheapest to buy because they
 - ▶ Don't have attachments to particular candidates
 - ▶ Pay attention to leaders' policies

WHY IS THIS QUESTION IMPORTANT?

For leaders:

- ▶ Be strategic about who you appeal with your actions

For group members:

- ▶ Make you appear more important to the leader

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WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF THE SLIDES BELOW?

We illustrated the importance of **responsiveness** using a simple game with particular numbers

You may worry the take aways crucially depend on the numbers we chose

A formal model shows you this is not the case!

We will **not** test you on the slides below

But some students learn better using formal models: these students are strongly encouraged to read those slides

PLAYERS: TWO POTENTIAL LEADERS AND THREE HETEROGENOUS GROUPS

Suppose there are two potential leaders, a and b

There are three heterogenous groups in this society:

- ▶ a partisans (A)
- ▶ b partisans (B)
- ▶ independents (I)

Suppose that the leader needs the support from at least two groups to win office

ACTIONS: LEADERS PROPOSE POLICIES, GROUPS CHOOSE WHOM TO SUPPORT

Suppose the leaders can choose between spending government resources on providing:

- ▶ Public goods to everyone (g)
- ▶ Private goods exclusively to the independents x_I
- ▶ For simplicity, the model will not include private goods exclusively to groups A and B . The result of the model is not affected

Each group chooses whether to support candidate a or b

PAYOFFS: WHAT DO THE LEADERS AND GROUPS WANT?

The leaders care only about winning office: assume benefit is 1

Every group gets a payoff of 1 from the public good

Independents, *I*, get a payoff of $\pi > 1$ from the private good

The partisan groups, *A* and *B*, care both about policy and about the identity of the leader

- ▶ Extra benefit $\eta > 0$ if partisan-aligned candidate wins

Independents, *I*, only care about policy

TIMING

The two candidates propose their policy platforms

After observing the proposed policy platforms, each group decides whom to support

- ▶ If they are indifferent, they flip a coin

Since this is a dynamic strategic situation, we solve it using backward induction

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 1: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = g, s_b = g)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate <i>a</i> proposes <i>g</i> and wins	Payoff if candidate <i>b</i> proposes <i>g</i> and wins	Support
<i>A</i>	$1 + \eta$	1	
<i>B</i>	1	$1 + \eta$	
<i>I</i>	1	1	

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Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes g and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes g and wins	Support
A	$1 + \eta$	1	a
B	1	$1 + \eta$	b
I	1	1	indifferent

Both candidates win with probability $\frac{1}{2}$

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 2: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$(s_a = x_I, s_b = x_I)$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support
A	η	0	
B	0	η	
I	π	π	

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 2: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$(s_a = x_I, s_b = x_I)$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support
A	η	0	a
B	0	η	b
I	π	π	indifferent

Both candidates win with probability $\frac{1}{2}$

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 3: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = x_I, s_b = g)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes g and wins	Support
A	η	1	
B	0	$1 + \eta$	
I	π	1	

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 3: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = x_I, s_b = g)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes g and wins	Support
A	η	1	
B	0	$1 + \eta$	b
I	π	1	a

Group A 's support depends on the value of η

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Suppose groups are **weakly** attached to candidates and hence **strongly** responsive to policy: $\eta < 1$

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Group A supports candidate b

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

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B	0	$1 + \eta$	b
I	π	1	a

Suppose groups are **weakly** attached to candidates and hence **strongly** responsive to policy: $\eta < 1$

Group A supports candidate b

Candidate b proposing the public good g gets support from two groups and wins

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 4: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = g, s_b = x_I)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes g and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support?
A	$1 + \eta$	0	
B	1	η	
I	1	π	

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 4: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = g, s_b = x_I)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes g and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support
A	$1 + \eta$	0	a
B	1	η	a
I	1	π	b

Suppose groups are **weakly** attached to candidates and hence **strongly** responsive to policy: $\eta < 1$

Group B supports candidate a

Candidate a proposing the public good g gets support from two groups and wins

FIRST STAGE: WHAT POLICIES WILL CANDIDATES PROPOSE WHEN $\eta < 1$?

For every potential combination of policy platforms and the value of η , we can determine the payoff to each candidate

When partisan groups are **weakly** attached to candidates ($\eta < 1$), candidates play the following game:

		Candidate b	
		g	x_I
Candidate a	g	$\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$	$1, 0$
	x_I	$0, 1$	$\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$

If partisans are **weakly** attached to candidates and hence **strongly responsive to policy**, candidates provide **public goods**

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 3: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = x_I, s_b = g)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes g and wins	Support?
A	η	1	
B	0	$1 + \eta$	
I	π	1	

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

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Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes x_I and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes g and wins	Support
A	η	1	a
B	0	$1 + \eta$	b
I	π	1	a

Suppose groups are **weakly** attached to candidates and hence **strongly** responsive to policy: $\eta < 1$

Group A supports candidate a

Candidate a proposing the private good x_I gets support from two groups and wins

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

Scenario 4: Suppose candidates propose the policies:

$$(s_a = g, s_b = x_I)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes g and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support?
A	$1 + \eta$	0	
B	1	η	
I	1	π	

LAST STAGE: WHO DO THE GROUPS SUPPORT?

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$$(s_a = g, s_b = x_I)$$

Group	Payoff if candidate a proposes g and wins	Payoff if candidate b proposes x_I and wins	Support
A	$1 + \eta$	0	a
B	1	η	b
I	1	π	b

Suppose groups are **strongly** attached to candidates and hence **weakly** responsive to policy: $\eta > 1$

Group B supports candidate b

Candidate b proposing the private good x_I gets support from two groups and wins

FIRST STAGE: WHAT POLICIES WILL CANDIDATES PROPOSE WHEN $\eta > 1$?

When partisan groups are **weakly** attached to candidates ($\eta > 1$), candidates play the following game:

		Candidate b	
		g	x_I
Candidate a	g	$\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$	$0, 1$
	x_I	$1, 0$	$\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}$

If partisans are **strongly** attached to candidates and hence **weakly responsive to policy**, candidates provide **private goods**